Development Digest

Welcome to our first Training & Development newsletter!

Have you ever noticed that some training sessions stick with you, while others quickly fade away? There are many factors at play, but one key element is often the learning method. Research consistently highlights the power of experiential learning.

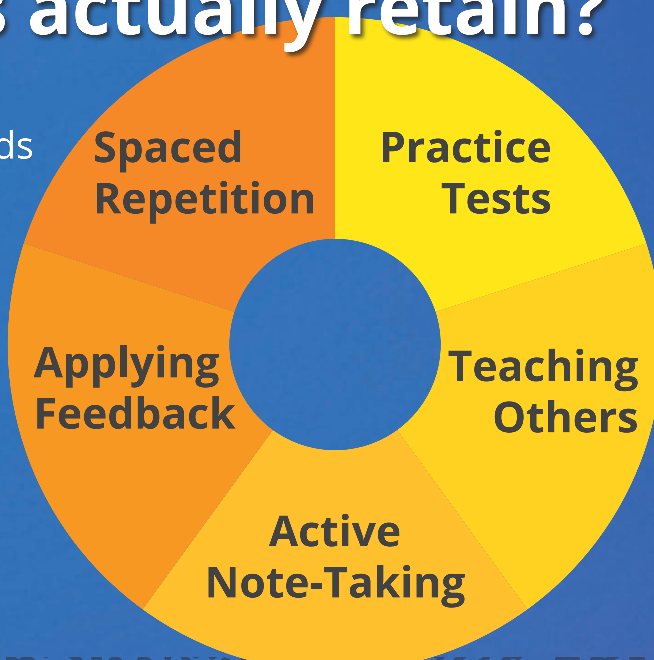
Experiential learning - simply put - is **learning by doing**! It is a hands-on approach that emphasizes learning through experience, reflection, and application. It's about engaging directly in activities and then reflecting on them, which builds critical thinking skills.

This method transforms *passive* learning into an *active*, immersive experience. **A Harvard study found that students gain more knowledge through active learning compared to passive learning**; despite this, traditional teaching methods are still commonly used (Deslauriers et al., 2019).

How much do learners actually retain?

This graphic (right) displays proven methods to boost retention (Harvard, 2024).

Even in the best case, we can't expect learners to retain everything, but we can take steps to help improve retention!



did you know?

While learning preferences exist, learning styles are a myth!

(Whitman, 2023)

When Active Learning isn't an Option

Not every course or curriculum can be built to include hands on learning experiences. For example, a software may not include a sandbox environment, or a complex topic may require foundational information before active learning happens. The good news is, there are proven ways to make those passive learning experiences more effective:

Make it meaningful:

- **Storytelling** may seem unnecessary or a "nice to have" if you will. However, stories spark emotion, which makes information memorable and relevant.
- **Value** is a key element in motivation to learn. That can be accomplished multiple ways - storytelling included! Value can be presented as a benefit to the learner (WIIFM) or even a consequence.

Make it easy to understand

- Tie in learners' previous experience when possible, but be extra careful if the information is brand new to learners
- Be mindful of cognitive overload
- **Simplify** whenever and however possible

Make time for reflection

- Providing intentional "thinking time" helps learners recall and understand
- Facilitated group discussion is also helpful!

Multimodal Learning in Action!

In truth, multimodal learning - which incorporates various ways to present informaton - is likely the best option for most programs. A primary reason for this is that it's highly engaging!

The great news is, our team already has several great examples of multimodal learning in our existing programs!

XX Phase 2: Exercise 2 combines visual learning (video) with a writing exercise

XYZ Phase 2: Exercise 3 is an example of reading *and* hands-on learning. Learners are asked to download and analyze data.

XY Phase 2 includes a video on Risk Services Manager, utilizing a visual learning modality

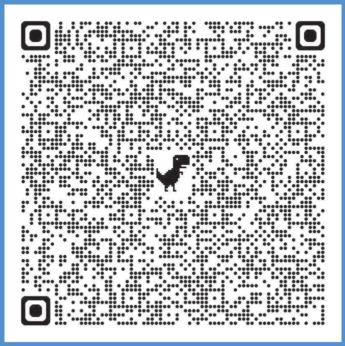
Let's Roll!

As we wrap up this month's topic, I ask you to imagine this: you want to learn to ride a bike. Would you start by reading all the books you could find about bicycle-riding, techniques, and so forth, and then jump on, expecting to start peddling like a pro? No. Eventually, you'd grab a helmet and get on the bike. Probably expecting to fall a few times, too!

This specific example is the one I use to remind myself to find ways to make learning active whenever possible.

More to Explore

Book:
Telling Ain't Training



Webinar:
The Neuroscience of Learning

References

American Psychological Association. (2019, May 29). *Belief in learning styles myth may be detrimental* [Press release]. https://www.apa.org/news/press/releases/2019/05/learning-styles-myth

Deslauriers, L., McCarty, L. S., Miller, K., Callaghan, K., & Kestin, G. (2019). Measuring actual learning versus feeling of learning in response to being actively engaged in the classroom. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America, 116*(39), 19251–19257. https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.182193611

Whitman, G. M. (2023). Learning Styles: Lack of Research-Based Evidence. *Clearing House, 96*(4), 111–115.https://doi-org.csuglobal.idm.oclc.org/10.1080/00098655.2023.2203891